

HORS D'OEUVRES | DILIP BOBB

Strangers on the Line



Last week, I was sitting in an airport lounge when I started to feel like a switchboard operator eavesdropping on private phone conversations. I was suddenly aware of intimate conversations going on all around me. It's amazing how much of a false sense of security mobile phones seem to provide. The guy on my left was yelling at his secretary 6,000 miles away for some missing documents: the boss from hell, a la Hari Sadu in the TV ad. Behind me, a sad narrative was unfolding as another pin-striped suit argued with his wife over their divorce settlement. The sharp dresser in the corner was whispering sweet nothings to someone who was obviously not his wife and the Prada-Gucci lady on my right was reliving her previous night to a friend, dropping names of celebs and high-priced restaurants and the diamond earring that had fallen off in his Ferrari. Without wanting to, I had become immersed in the private life of total strangers. It's a social consequence to do with the speed at which technology is evolving and taking control of our lives. At a recent Norwegian seminar, speakers agreed that the mobile phone is fundamentally changing social relations, not least in public places. Cocooned within our "Personal Area Networks" and wirelessly transported to other spaces, we are becoming increasingly immune to the boundaries and realities of physical space, inadvertently revealing or becoming privy to, astonishingly intimate details about others. It's a fascinating mix of visibility and inaccessibility, intimacy and alienation that symbolises the mobile call in a public place.

Sociologist Irvine Goffman tried to analyse why people who normally keep their private life to themselves reveal personal details to strangers around them when speaking on their cellphones in public spaces. In some cases, as the Prada-Gucci lady exemplifies, the mobile is used by electronic exhibitionists, someone who wants to announce to the world what an enviable life she or he lives. Goffman's theory was that the mobile functions as a shield, like a newspaper or a book. It erects a communicative barrier between the caller and others. The difference is that readers do not comment verbally on what they are reading. There is also something about strangers in

public places that makes intimacy possible: the very fact that they are strangers. The mobile user also benefits from what Goffman called 'civil inattention' from the others. Civil inattention is expressed by strangers pretending that they are not listening, even while eavesdropping. This prompts the mobile user to perceive others as a mass and not as hearing individuals. In a world where social space is overtaken by anonymous, unavoidable background noise, it seems inevitable that we are becoming more intimate with strangers than people we know.

COCOONED WITHIN OUR 'PERSONAL AREA NETWORKS' WE ARE BECOMING IMMUNE TO THE BOUNDARIES OF PHYSICAL SPACE, INADVERTENTLY REVEALING OR BECOMING PRIVY TO INTIMATE DETAILS ABOUT OTHERS.



SAURABH SINGH/www.indiatodayimages.com

SIGNPOSTS

UPHELD: By the Supreme Court, the Delhi High Court's life sentence to **Manu Sharma**, convicted for the murder of Jessica Lall in 1999. Manu is the son of senior Congress leader Venod Sharma. The



MANU SHARMA

apex court also upheld the convictions of Vikas Yadav and Amarjeet Singh Gill for destruction of evidence in the case.

WON: By Gagan Narang, the bronze medal in the 10-m air rifle event at the World Cup in Beijing. This is his sixth World Cup medal.

APPOINTED: Tsewang Topden as the ambassador to Greece. He is currently the high commissioner to Namibia.

LAUNCHED: India's first indigenously built anti-submarine warfare corvette named **Kamorta**. It is designated as a frontline warship with anti-submarine warfare capabilities and a very low signature of radiated underwater noise. It will be docked at the Eastern Naval Command.